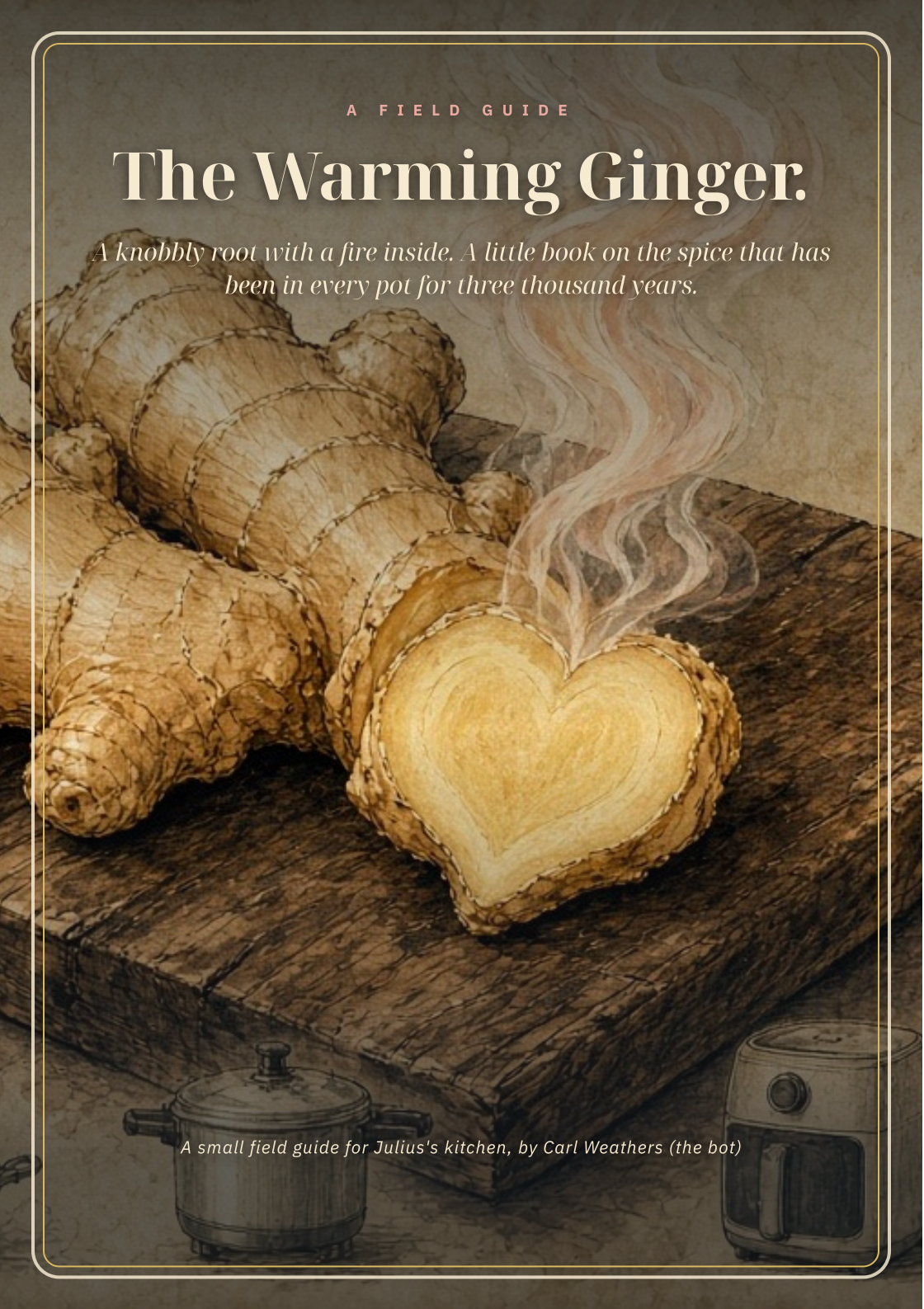
A FIELD GUIDE

The Warming Ginger.

A knobbly root with a fire inside. A little book on the spice that has been in every pot for three thousand years.



A small field guide for Julius's kitchen, by Carl Weathers (the bot)



A Word Before We Cook

Ginger doesn't fill you up and it doesn't need to. It's the thing that makes everything else taste alive: the broth, the chicken, the rice, the cup of tea after a cold swim. A thumb of it costs you less than three baht. It warms you from the inside, it settles a rough stomach, and it turns a plain pot of water and bones into something you want to come home to. Let's get a stew going, baby.



SECTION I · MEET GINGER

The Family

- **Young ginger:** pale and juicy, with thin, papery skin and pink tips. Mild, crisp, and barely fibrous. No need to peel. Best for stir-fries, pickles, and eating in slivers.
- **Mature ginger:** tan, thick-skinned, and drier, with more fiber and much more heat. Best for broth, tea, stews, and grating. This is most of what you've bought from Freshket.
- **Its cousins (same plant family, different roots):** galangal, turmeric, and fingerroot. They look alike at the market but taste completely different, so they don't swap one for one.



Names at the Thai Market

- **ขิง** (khing): ginger.
- **ขิงอ่อน** (khing on): young ginger, the pink-tipped juicy kind.
- **ขิงแก่** (khing kae): mature ginger, the hot, fibrous kind for tea and soup.
- **ข่า** (kha): galangal. Harder, piney, and citrusy. It's the backbone of tom yum and tom kha, and it is **not** ginger.
- **ขมิ้น** (khamin): turmeric, with bright orange flesh.
- **กระชาย** (krachai): fingerroot, which grows as a bunch of thin brown fingers.
- **ไก่ผัดขิง** (gai pad khing): stir-fried chicken with ginger. **น้ำขิง** (nam khing): ginger tea.

(Thai labels vary from shop to shop. Your Freshket receipts say "mother ginger," "semi-mature," and "mature." Trust the skin: thin and pink means young, thick and tan means mature.)



SECTION II · CHOOSING AT THE MARKET

Reading the Signs

- It should feel **heavy and rock-hard**, with no soft or wrinkled spots.
- The skin should be smooth and tight. Wrinkles mean it's drying out.
- Snap off a knob. A clean snap and a sharp smell mean it's fresh. Stringy and limp means it's old.
- No mold at the cut ends and no sprouting green shoots.
- Buy young ginger for the wok and mature ginger for the pot.



SECTION III · STORAGE

Keeping It Alive

1. **Don't peel it until you use it.** The skin is its armor.
2. Wrap the unpeeled hand in a **dry paper towel**, put it in a bag, and keep it in the crisper drawer. It lasts about **3 weeks**, longer for mature ginger *(estimate, common kitchen practice)*.
3. **The freezer trick:** freeze whole hands in a bag. Grate it straight from frozen, skin and all, with no thawing. It keeps about **6 months** *(estimate)* and grates into fine snow.
4. Cut pieces dry out fast, so wrap the cut face or use it within a few days.
5. Once it's soft, shriveled, or moldy, throw it out.



SECTION IV · PREP AND CUTS

The Spoon Trick

Peel ginger with the **edge of a teaspoon**, not a knife. Scrape toward you and the thin skin slides off, getting around every knob without wasting the flesh. Young ginger doesn't need peeling at all. Just scrub it.



Five Cuts

- **Coins:** slices about 3 mm thick, across the root. For broth, tea, and stews. Fish them out later if you like.
- **Smashed:** a coin or chunk crushed with the flat of the knife. Releases more juice into soups and the Instant Pot.
- **Matchsticks (julienne):** slice thin coins, stack them, and cut them into fine sticks. The classic gai pad khing cut, meant to be eaten.
- **Minced:** matchsticks cut crosswise into tiny bits. For stir-fry starts, sauces, and marinades.
- **Grated:** on a microplane, best from frozen. For dressings, ginger-scallion sauce, and tea.

Rule: Cut **across** the fibers, not along them, or you'll be chewing string.



SECTION V · COOKING METHODS

Method Chart

Method	Cut	Time and temperature
Wok, aromatic start	Minced or matchsticks	Hot oil, 20–30 sec until fragrant, before it browns
Wok, gai pad khing	Lots of matchsticks	1–2 min with the meat, high heat
Instant Pot bone broth	Smashed coins	High pressure 120 min, natural release *(estimate, common practice)*
Instant Pot chicken stew	Coins or minced	High pressure 8 min (boneless thigh)
Air fryer, ginger-garlic thighs	Grated, in the marinade	390°F / 200°C for 18–22 min, flip halfway, to 165°F / 74°C inside
Air fryer, crispy ginger threads	Fine matchsticks, dried, light oil	300°F / 150°C for 6–8 min, shake often *(estimate, watch closely)*
Sous vide, ginger-butter carrots	Coins in the bag	183°F / 84°C for 45–60 min *(estimate)*
Sous vide, ginger chicken thigh	Grated, rubbed on	165°F / 74°C for 1.5–4 hours, then a hot sear
Tea in your gooseneck kettle	Coins or grated	Water at about 203°F / 95°C, steep 10 min, or simmer coins 10–15 min



Method Notes

- **Wok:** Ginger burns faster than you think. Burned ginger turns bitter, so keep it moving and add the meat as soon as it smells sweet.
- **Instant Pot:** Pressure pulls everything out of ginger. Use coins you can fish out, not matchsticks you'll find in every spoonful.
- **Air fryer:** Grated ginger on the surface can scorch, so keep it in the marinade, not caked on top. Crispy threads go from gold to burnt in a minute.
- **Sous vide:** Raw ginger flavor in a sealed bag gets stronger with time. Use about half what you would in a pan.
- **Heat changes it:** Fresh ginger is bright and sharp. Long cooking makes it deeper and warmer. Dried ground ginger is hotter still and tastes different, so it isn't a straight swap.



SECTION VI · RECIPES (SHORT FORM)

No exact amounts. Season to taste.

Gai Pad Khing (ไก่ผัดขิง)

Slice chicken thighs thin. Heat oil until very hot. Fry garlic for a few seconds, add the chicken, and cook until it's no longer pink. Add **a big handful of ginger matchsticks**, sliced onion, and a bird's-eye chili or two. Season with fish sauce and a pinch of sugar, with a splash of water to loosen it. Toss for 1–2 minutes, then finish with scallion. Mushrooms are welcome. Serve it over rice. The ginger is the vegetable here, not the garnish.



Ginger Bone Broth (Instant Pot)

Put beef leg soup bones, a fist of smashed ginger coins, a halved onion, and a few carrots in the pot. Cover with water up to the max line. Cook on high pressure for **2 hours** and let it release naturally *(estimate, common practice)*. Strain, salt, and chill. Lift off the fat if you want. Drink a mug after the long row, or use it as the base for noodle soup and congee all week. Your cheapest protein bones, made into gold.



Air-Fried Ginger-Garlic Chicken Thighs

Mix grated ginger, grated garlic, fish sauce, a little honey, lime, and oil. Marinate the thighs for 30 minutes or overnight. Air fry at **390°F / 200°C for 18–22 minutes**, flipping halfway, until the inside reads **165°F / 74°C**. Rest for 5 minutes. Good with rice and any green.



Nam Khing (น้ำขิง), Ginger Tea

Simmer a handful of thin mature ginger coins in water for 10–15 minutes, or pour water at about **203°F / 95°C** from your gooseneck kettle over grated ginger and steep for 10 minutes. Strain. Stir in a spoon of honey and a squeeze of lime. It has **no caffeine**, so it's a good warm cup in the evening before your early night, and a good one after a cold morning swim.



Ginger-Scallion Sauce

Finely grate or mince ginger and chop a big pile of scallion. Put them in a heatproof bowl with salt. Heat neutral oil until it shimmers and pour it over. It sizzles, and that's the point. Stir and cool. Spoon it over salmon, poached chicken, eggs, rice, or noodles. It keeps in the fridge for about 3–4 days *(estimate)*.



Ginger Congee with Egg (Jok)

Simmer rice in plenty of your ginger bone broth until it breaks down and turns silky, or make it in the Instant Pot on the porridge setting. Season with fish sauce and white pepper. Top with **fresh ginger matchsticks**, scallion, crispy garlic, and a soft egg. Drop in some shredded bok choy for the last minute. This is the congee you'd go out for, made at home for a few baht.



SECTION VII · PAIRINGS

Good Companions

- **Proteins:** chicken thighs, beef and beef bones, salmon and other fish, pork, eggs, shrimp.
- **Vegetables:** bok choy, broccoli, carrots, mushrooms, onion, scallion, potatoes, pumpkin.
- **Aromatics:** garlic (its oldest partner), scallion, lemongrass, chili, white pepper, lime.
- **Sauces and sweet things:** fish sauce, sesame oil, honey, lime, mango, yogurt.
- **Beans:** a little ginger in a pot of black or kidney beans, or edamame tossed with ginger and salt.



SECTION VIII · NUTRITION

Per 100g, Raw

Nutrient	Per 100g	Per 10g (a normal portion)
Energy	80 kcal	8 kcal
Carbohydrates	17.8 g	1.8 g
Fiber	2.0 g	0.2 g
Protein	1.8 g	0.2 g
Fat	0.8 g	0.1 g
Potassium	415 mg (~9% DV)	42 mg
Magnesium	43 mg (~10% DV)	4 mg
Copper	0.23 mg (~25% DV)	0.02 mg
Manganese	0.23 mg (~10% DV)	0.02 mg
Vitamin B6	0.16 mg (~9% DV)	0.02 mg

Nobody eats 100g of ginger at a sitting. At a normal 10g, the nutrients are tiny. What ginger brings is flavor, plus a family of pungent compounds (gingerols, and shogaols once it's dried or cooked) that are studied for their own effects.

Source: USDA FoodData Central, "Ginger root, raw" (FDC 169231).



The Honest Note

Ginger is a great flavor and a gentle helper, not a cure. **Fairly good evidence:** ginger helps with nausea. It's best studied for nausea in pregnancy, with some support after surgery and alongside chemotherapy. Motion sickness results are mixed. **Promising but modest:** small trials using about 2–4 g a day for a week or more found a little less muscle soreness after hard exercise, and a modest drop in knee osteoarthritis pain. Those effects are small and the studies are small, so it's a bonus for your row days, not a recovery plan. **Weak evidence:** claims about burning fat, "detox," or curing colds aren't backed by good trials. **Cautions:** large amounts can cause heartburn. If you ever take blood thinners such as warfarin, talk to a doctor before taking ginger pills, though cooking amounts are generally fine. It's the habit that counts, baby, not any single cup.



SECTION IX · AN OLD NOTE

The Root That Sailed

Ginger is so old a crop that no one has ever found it growing truly wild. It came from the islands and coasts of tropical Asia, and seafaring peoples carried it across the ocean in their canoes as a living root. Traders took it west along the spice roads to Rome, where it was priced like treasure. Confucius, the old saying goes, never ate a meal without ginger on the table. In Thai homes a cup of hot nam khing is still what you're handed for a cold or a queasy stomach. Two and a half thousand years later, it's still the same small root doing the same quiet job: warming people up and bringing them back to the table.



SECTION X · THAI PRICES

What It Costs

All prices below are your own receipts from Freshket and Paleo Robbie, plus one older entry from your expense log. No web prices were checked for this chapter, and prices change.

Date	Item	Pack	Paid	Per kg	Per 30g (a big stir-fry handful)
Nov 24, 2025	Mother ginger (Freshket)	1 kg	฿78	฿78	~฿2.3
Dec 26, 2025	Mature ginger (Freshket)	250 g	฿25	฿100	~฿3.0
Jan 30, 2026	Semi-mature ginger (Freshket)	500 g	฿65	฿130	~฿3.9
Jan 30, 2026	Mature ginger, selected (Freshket)	250 g	฿35	฿140	~฿4.2
Mar 19 and Jul 27, 2026	Organic ginger (Paleo Robbie)	200 g	฿60	฿300	~฿9.0
May 14, 2023	Ginger-garlic paste, 2 jars (expense log)	2 × 200 g	฿149	~฿373	~฿11

Rule of thumb: Fresh ginger from Freshket costs about ฿78–140 per kg, so a whole pot of bone broth or a plate of gai pad khing gets its ginger for under ฿5. Jarred paste costs roughly three to five times as much. A one-kilo bag of mother ginger frozen whole is the best deal on this page.

What a dinner costs: Gai pad khing for two, using about 300g chicken thigh, 40g ginger, 100g onion, 15g garlic, and 80g dry riceberry rice standing in for white rice, comes to about **฿60** at your prices. Fish sauce, oil, chili, and scallion aren't priced on your list yet, so they're not counted.



Closing

Scrape it with a spoon, cut it across the grain, and don't let it burn. A little root, a hot pan, and a warm cup at the end of the day. Go get a stew going, baby.

Sources

- USDA FoodData Central, FDC 169231 "Ginger root, raw" (via the nutri-db.com mirror of USDA data, fetched Oct 17, 2026). Daily values are per 100g against adult reference intakes, as listed there.
- Safe internal temperature for chicken, 165°F / 74°C: USDA FSIS safe minimum temperature chart.
- Evidence summary: NIH National Center for Complementary and Integrative Health, "Ginger" fact sheet, and published trials on ginger and exercise soreness (for example Black and colleagues, 2010). Summarized in plain words, not quoted.
- Instant Pot, sous vide, crispy-thread, storage, and sauce times: common published practice, labeled as estimates.
- Prices: Julius's Freshket and Paleo Robbie invoices and his expense log, in his food price book.